

Networking: Effective Strategies To Stand Out

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- Networking: The process of making connections, building relationships and fostering them.
- Occurs in various settings such as online platforms, workshops, informal gatherings, industry events, and professional associations.
- Offers valuable advice and professional contacts that can help in making informed career decisions and creating mutually beneficial relationships.
- “85% of jobs are secured through networking efforts.” – HubSpot.

Three-Step Guide to Master Networking

Before Networking



Clearly Define Your Goals And Values

Ex: Your goal is on advancing your future career path.
⇒ Seek out individuals with relevant expertise and experiences.

Find the right connections and communicate your unique value proposition.



Thoughtfully Research

Familiarize with your contact’s professional background: LinkedIn profiles, company websites, bios, publications, and articles about your contacts or their company.

Formulate questions that genuinely interest you and align with the topics.

During Networking



Win At Your First Impression

A firm handshake, a customized and concise pitch, and a right-for-the-occasion attire can set a positive tone for a productive conversation.

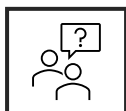
Build confidence and deepen the conversation.



Be In the Moment

Focus entirely to your contact — avoid checking your phone. Guide the conversation toward the topics that intrigued you in their previous response.

Show authentic enthusiasm and courteousness.



Ask The Right Questions

Ask positive questions and re-frame sensitive ones: Rather than, “What do you hate about your job?” Use, “What are some challenges in your role?”

Foster an uplifting atmosphere.

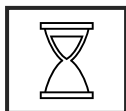


Perform Effective Body Language

Smile genuinely to show you are approachable and that you like the person you are talking to.

Maintain eye contact and avoid excessive staring.

Demonstrate your confidence, respect, and trust.



Respect Everyone’s Time

For in-person, keep your conversation brief, around 5-7 minutes, to give others a chance to engage.

Increase likelihood of scheduling follow-ups.

Helpful Note

Regardless of personality type, engage networking by adapting an extroverted persona, as it would ease the conversation and foster a better connection.

After Networking



Follow-Up With A Thank You Note

Personalize your communication by mentioning personal details (e.g., a shared hobby) and ask for informational interviews/coffee chats.

Demonstrate your active pursuit of opportunities.



Occasionally Check-In With Your Contacts

Connect to helpful resources and introductions in your network. Engage semi frequently with professional updates or send follow ups to seek advice.

Showcase your expertise and build credibility.

Organize collected contact information promptly including their position, organization sector, and any personal details.

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Do's of Asking Questions

About Contact

How did you choose this career and get to where you are professionally now?
How does your organization compare with its competitors?

Career Path

What has your career path been, and what does the typical career path look like for someone in this field?
How has the field changed since you started?

College Experience

If you could go back to undergrad, what would your approach be?
What aspects of your college experience did you find to be particularly useful when entering the professional world?

Personal Advice

What are the key aspects of a high-quality prospective candidate?
What are skills, personal qualities, or abilities are important to being successful in this job?

Don'ts of Asking Questions

Directly Request Referral

Can you refer me to a position at your company?
What job openings can you refer me to?

Ask For Help Without Demonstrating Your Value

Can you connect me with your firm's hiring manager?
Is there any colleague of yours you could refer me to?

Intrude Personal Life

How much is your salary?
What do you dislike about your job/company?

Inappropriate and Sensitive Topics

Politics and Current Controversial Events
Work or Study Complaints

Questions Easily Answered by Google

Not tailored to the professional's background
Non-substantive questions

Key Takeaways & Practice Tips

Perfect Storytelling

Tailor narratives and strive to keep them engaging.
A finance professional might say, "I help executives make critical financial decisions," followed by a brief, illustrative example.

A Personal Fact

Share a personal life fact before diving into a pitch.
Pique curiosity and establish a genuine human connection by making conversation feel more genuine.

Positive Communication

Frame stories about past challenges positively, emphasizing lessons learned.
Leave a favorable impression by embracing growth and personal development.

Extensively Practice

Use mirrors or recorded Teams/Zoom calls to practice.
Improve your fluency and active listening by practicing in a controlled space.

Yes, and...

Keep conversations flowing by active listening.
Make others feel heard and valued, as judgement usually leads to disconnection.

Odd-Number Group

Aim for groups with an odd number of individuals.
Someone is likely seeking a conversation partner outside the current discussion.

A strategically aligned LinkedIn profile, a well-crafted resume, and proactive networking form a powerful combination for career development.

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